

Unexpected Side Effects and Complications of Diabetes

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When you hear “diabetes,” your mind likely jumps to problems with producing insulin and [regulating blood sugar](#). And that’s definitely a key part of this chronic disease, which affects nearly 1 in 10 Americans, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). But that’s also just the tip of the iceberg.

“Diabetes is like termites, in that it causes slow, hidden, but significant damage in the body,” says Osama Hamdy, M.D., Ph.D., director of the Inpatient Diabetes Program at the Joslin Diabetes Center in Boston. “Most patients with type 2 diabetes die from a heart attack,” Dr. Hamdy says, “but because the disease doesn’t have many symptoms, people tend to take it lightly.”

And evidence continues to mount that diabetes affects every system in the body, wreaking havoc if it’s not well managed. Learn more below about the side effects of diabetes and how you can protect yourself from complications. (The good news: Most can be avoided by following the treatment plan set out by your doctor.)

High blood pressure and cholesterol

When you have type 2 diabetes, your body can’t properly use insulin, a hormone that regulates blood sugar. In turn, your HDL (or “good”) cholesterol lowers, and your levels of harmful blood fats called triglycerides rise. Insulin resistance also contributes to hardened, narrow arteries, which in turn [increases your blood pressure](#).

As a result, about 2 of 3 people with diabetes also have hypertension—a risk factor for stroke, heart disease, and trouble with thinking and memory. Failing to control high blood pressure and high cholesterol, either [with diet and exercise alone](#) or by adding medications, accelerates the rate at which all your other complications progress, says Robert Gabbay, M.D., Ph.D., chief medical officer at Joslin Diabetes Center in Boston.

Gum disease

People with diabetes are more likely to develop periodontal disease, an [infection of the gum and bone](#) that can lead to painful chewing problems and tooth loss. “This is due in part to elevated blood sugar that modifies the collagen in all of our tissues,” Dr. Rodbard says. “It’s also due to a slight increase in susceptibility to infections of all kinds.”

On the other hand, gum disease—specifically inflammation of the gums or development of deep abscesses—can raise blood sugar and make diabetes harder to control, according to Dr. Hamdy. To prevent periodontitis, brush and floss daily and consider using a mild antiseptic mouthwash to knock out any lingering plaque.

Adapted from “**10 Unexpected Side Effects and Complications of Diabetes, According to Doctors**”<https://www.prevention.com/health/g20481244/unexpected-side-effects-of-diabetes/>